Intel Developer Forum 2014

An overview of what to expect from Intel in 2014-15

Soham Raninga
soham.raninga@digit.in

Highlights from IDF 2014

Intel Corporation CEO Brian Krzanich kicked off Intel's annual technical conference with a clear focus on new markets such as wearable tech, mobile and connected devices.

While Intel continues to push the limits in traditional computing spaces, the focus of this year's IDF was clear – Intel is going after the new device categories and is preparing to develop the hardware and software development kits (SDKs) that will empower developers and manufacturers to quickly integrate its latest solutions into mass market products for new device categories. At IDF 2014, Intel outlined its plan around the new initiatives and products that are well beyond the traditional PC space.

No, they aren't ignoring the PC space, showcasing new Core M based hybrid PCs with fan-less design and a glimpse of the Skylake platform is an assurance of the fact that they will continue to press for dominance in the microprocessor segment, while targeting to enter several other segments.

Intel Reference Design for Android

Intel Reference Design for Android is the company's strongest signal so far about its seriousness towards mobile devices and the Android platform. You will see a lot of Intel based Android tablets and smartphones in 2014-15. Intel revealed its new Android Reference Design program for tablets, allowing manufacturers to quickly adopt Intel's x86 based SoCs. Intel seems to be very confident about its reference design program, promising Android updates within two weeks of Google making new releases available. Intel plans top do this by providing a single binary image and providing a list of pre-qualified components for tablets and phones.

At the event, we had a chance to play with Intel Merrifield and Moorefield based smartphones and tablets from Asus, Dell & Lenovo. Merrifield and Moorefield are based on Intel's 22nm SoC process; Merrifield houses two Silvermont cores with 1MB shared L2 cache and is aimed primarily at smartphones while Moorefield has 4 cores and 2MB shared L2 cache. These SoCs are offered for mid-range and budget devices priced within $500.

One of the new markets that Intel has on its radar is wearable devices and it's doing so with MICA. MICA (My Intelligent Communication Accessory) was first unveiled at Fashion Week in New York and Intel discussed strategies and game-plans for the platform at IDF.

Intel CEO, Brian Krzanich defines MICA as "This is something you want to wear independent of the technology inside and when you realize what the technology inside is, you've got to have one". While Intel hasn't revealed much on the core technology aspects of any of its wearable device initiatives, the MICA Smart Bracelet claims that it "allows you to stay connected via SMS messages, meeting alerts, and general notifications delivered directly to the wrist, with additional features and functions to be revealed at a later date."

Intel also announced its partnership with American watch and fashion accessory brand– Fossil. While there weren't any smart watches announced or demoed at the event, one can expect smart devices and watches from this partnership soon, especially after the announcement of Apple Watch.

Empowering 'Makers' with Edison

Apart from developers, Intel is targeting the inventors/builders segment, coined